

Practice Paper 3 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “Very politely, to betray me”

1 mark for understanding that her body / fingers are letting her down despite her wish to remain composed; **1 mark** for the idea that the failure is **subtle** / **quiet**, rather than obvious — a small, controlled trembling rather than open shaking.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that her nerves were **quietly undermining her control** of her own body. Her fingers were **not yet visibly shaking**, but they had begun to fail her in a small, almost discreet way, which made the betrayal feel all the more unsettling.

Q2. [2] — “A piece of metal just before it snaps”

1 mark for identifying that the comparison conveys **extreme inner tension** / **strain**; **1 mark** for the **sense of imminent collapse** — she feels she is on the edge of breaking down.

Sample answer: The comparison (a **simile**) suggests that the narrator is **under enormous pressure**, like metal stretched to its limit. It also suggests she feels **close to breaking** — that one further moment of strain might shatter her composure entirely.

Q3. [2] — “Half in shadow, half in the warm orange spill of the stage lights”

1 mark each for any two of:

- The image shows the mother is **partly present, partly withdrawn** — close enough to support, distant enough not to interfere.
- The **warm light** on her suggests **warmth, reassurance, comfort**.
- The **shadow** suggests her **quiet, unobtrusive** role — she does not intrude into her daughter’s performance.
- Together, the image suggests a mother who **belongs both to her daughter’s private world and to the public stage** of the performance.

Q4. [2] — “Inconveniently”

1 mark — The narrator **cannot afford** the **emotional weight** of love at that moment, because she must focus on her performance.

1 mark — The word suggests that strong feelings are a **distraction** and a **burden** — they get in the way of the concentration she desperately needs. It also hints at **self-deprecating humour** — she knows it is irrational to resent loving her mother.

Q5. [2] — “Dry as turning paper”

(a) [1]: The simile suggests the whisper was **thin, brittle and businesslike** — there is **no warmth or encouragement** in it; the stage manager is simply doing his job.

(b) [1]: It is effective because it makes the moment feel **cold and impersonal** in contrast to the narrator’s mother’s warm gesture, and it **heightens the narrator’s isolation** just before she must walk out.

Q6. [2] — Importance of the small gesture

1 mark — The use of **contrast** — “smallest” set against “only one I needed” — emphasises that **something tiny had a huge effect** on the narrator.

1 mark — The use of two **short, parallel sentences** in succession makes each statement feel weighty and considered, almost like a quiet declaration; the brevity itself **mirrors** the smallness of the gesture while underlining its emotional force.

Q7. [2] — Piano as “a small black animal”

1 mark for identifying the **metaphor** — the piano is given the qualities of a living animal; **1 mark** for explaining the **effect** — it makes the piano feel **unpredictable, watchful, and slightly dangerous**, as though it must be **approached carefully** rather than simply played.

Sample answer: The piano is **personified** as a wary animal. This makes the instrument feel **alive and possibly hostile**, suggesting that the narrator now sees it as something she must **handle with care**, not a familiar tool she can trust.

Q8. [1] — Evidence body was no longer fully under control

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- She “adjusted [the bench] with hands that I no longer entirely owned.”
- “For a moment I could not feel my feet” (Paragraph 3, but accept if cross-referenced).
- The fact that she had to close her eyes “for a count of three” to regain control.

Q9. [2] — “The fear is information, not an instruction”

1 mark — Fear is **useful data**: it tells the performer that something matters and that her body is alert.

1 mark — But fear should **not dictate** her actions; she does **not have to obey it** by retreating or panicking — she can acknowledge the feeling and still continue to perform.

Q10. [2] — “It did not vanish. It moved aside.”

1 mark — The fear **did not disappear** — it was still present in the hall.

1 mark — But it **no longer controlled her**; it had become an **onlooker** rather than an obstacle, allowing her to play freely while remaining aware of its presence.

Q11. [1] — Tone of final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **tender, proud, moved, quietly triumphant, affectionate**. (Reject: **sad, disappointed** — these miss the emotional warmth of the moment.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “Settled fact ... fixed and natural as the seven-day calendar”

1 mark for understanding that people regarded the five-day week as **permanent and unquestionable**.

1 mark for the idea that it was treated as something **natural rather than chosen** — as if it had always existed and could not reasonably be altered, in the same way that nobody questions the length of the week.

Q13. [2] — “The dreamy property of leftist think tanks”

1 mark — **Dreamy** suggests the idea was seen as **unrealistic / impractical / idealistic** — wishful thinking rather than a serious proposal.

1 mark — **Leftist think tanks** suggests it was **dismissed as politically biased** — confined to a narrow group of left-wing theorists rather than taken seriously by mainstream business or government.

Q14. [2] — Evidence of Icelandic success

1 mark each for any two of:

- Productivity **held steady or improved** despite reduced hours.
- Researchers described it as “**an overwhelming success**”.
- Icelandic unions have since negotiated shorter hours for **roughly 86 per cent** of the country’s workforce.
- The trial covered **2,500 workers** across many sectors — schools, offices, hospitals and social services — with no cut in pay.

Q15. [2] — Purpose of “These are not the numbers ... coasting through a long weekend”

1 mark — To **pre-empt the obvious objection** that workers given an extra day off would simply **slack off / take it easy**.

1 mark — To **reinforce** the credibility of the trial’s findings by pointing out that the data (rising revenue, falling resignations, improved well-being) does not look like the data of a **lazy workforce** — it looks like a **more engaged** one.

Q16. [2] — “Hours worked and work actually done are not the same thing” (own words)

1 mark — The **time spent at work** is not equal to the **amount of useful work produced**.

1 mark — A person may sit at a desk for many hours yet **complete relatively little**, because much of the day is lost to interruptions, meetings, and other unproductive activity.

Reject lifted phrases such as “focused output” without rewording.

Q17. [2] — Two ways a four-day week improves work

1 mark each for any two of:

- It **forces organisations to remove inefficiency** — to **shorten meetings** and **automate routine tasks**.
- It results in **better-rested staff** who make **sharper decisions**.
- It produces **lower staff turnover** (fewer resignations).
- It encourages employers to **trust employees to manage their own time**.

Q18. [2] — Hospital ward, fire station, 24-hour port

1 mark — The three examples are all **sectors in which physical presence is the work itself** — patients, fires and ships cannot be paused for a day off.

1 mark — Listing them together highlights that the four-day week, which works in **office / knowledge industries**, may be **impractical in essential, round-the-clock services**; the rhetorical question forces the reader to confront this limitation.

Q19. [1] — Inverted commas around “a four-day week”

1 mark — The inverted commas signal that the writer is using the phrase **sceptically / ironically** — to show that, for low-paid shift workers, the phrase does **not really mean** what its supporters claim; it is a **label** being applied to a very different and harsher reality.

Q20. [1] — Tone of “a perk for the salaried middle class and a burden for everyone else”

1 mark — Any **one of: critical, disapproving, sceptical, cautionary, pointed**. (Reject: **neutral, amused, playful**.)

Q21. [2] — “No longer respectable” (own words)

1 mark — The old belief that **longer hours automatically produce more output** can **no longer be defended** as a sensible position.

1 mark — It has been **discredited by evidence** — even critics of the four-day week now accept that **more time at the desk does not mean more useful work**, and so it is **intellectually embarrassing** to hold the view in public.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points ($\frac{1}{2}$ mark each, max 6 marks). Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.

Benefits of the four-day working week (Paragraphs 3–4):

1. **Most participating companies** (92%) **chose to keep** the new schedule after the trial.
2. **Revenue rose** (by 1.4% on average) and **resignations fell sharply** (by 57%).
3. Employees reported **less stress, burnout and sleep difficulty**, and **better family life and exercise**.
4. It **forces firms to cut wasted time** — shorter meetings, automated tasks, fewer interruptions.
5. It produces **better-rested staff, sharper decisions, and lower turnover**.

Limitations and objections (Paragraphs 5–6):

6. Some employers object **on principle** — a contract for five days should be honoured for five.

7. Most pilots involved **knowledge work**; it is **unclear how the model fits essential services** such as hospitals, fire stations or 24-hour ports, where it would require **more hiring, overtime, or reduced cover**.
8. The benefit may **not reach low-paid shift workers**, who could end up working **the same hours compressed into longer, harder days** — risking a **perk for the middle class and a burden for the rest**.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Supporters of the four-day working week claim that it boosts company performance: most trial firms kept the new schedule, revenue rose, resignations fell, and workers reported less stress and better family life. They argue it forces firms to cut wasted time, producing rested staff and sharper decisions. Critics, however, object on principle, doubt it suits essential services like hospitals or ports, and warn that low-paid shift workers may simply find their hours compressed into longer, harsher days.

Length count: 78 words from “Supporters” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —